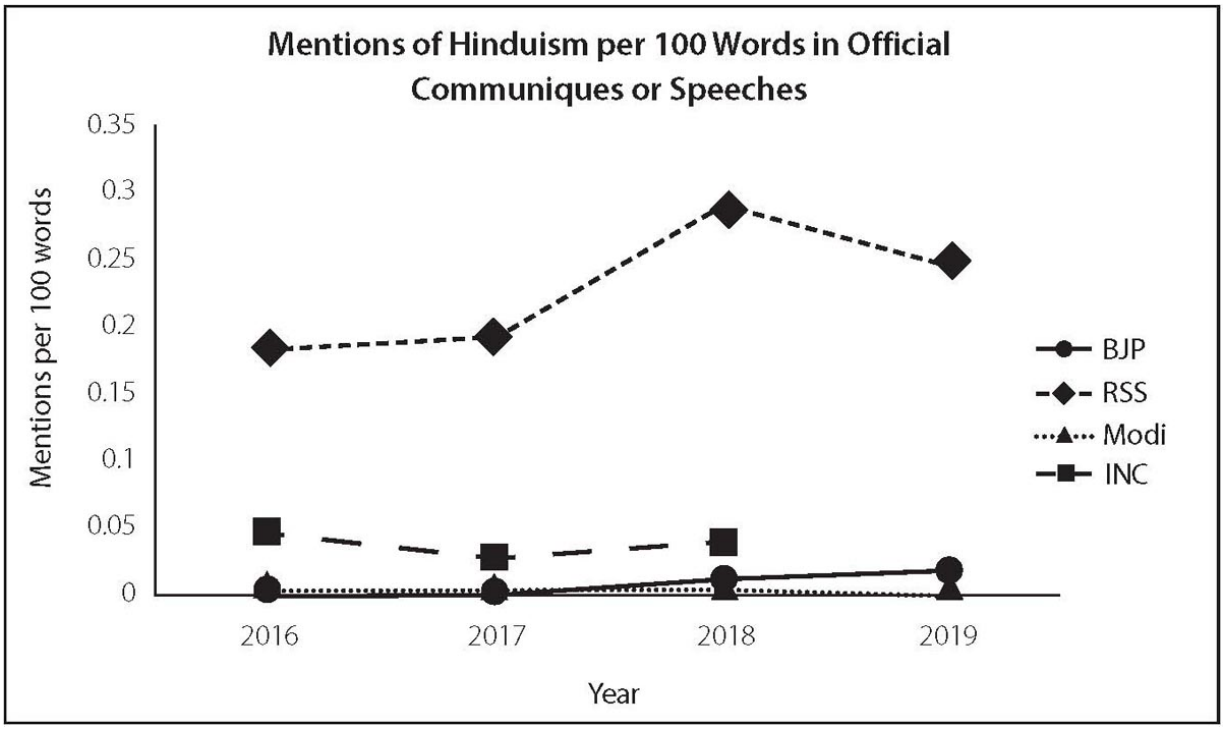


Source: Narad Index, Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava; for details see Appendix 4.

The RSS, Hindutva and the Hindu Rashtra

Why the RSS Thinks Hindutva Is the Same as Hinduism and Bharatiyata

While the RSS's quantitative focus on what it sees as 'Hindu' issues is clear, it is important to understand what it means by these terms in qualitative terms. As a number of scholars who have studied the RSS and its thinking over the decades have shown, these positions are not static and keep evolving. When the Sangh uses terms like 'Hindutva' and 'Hindu Rashtra', the question is, how does it understand them in the 2020s, beyond what its leaders thought in the 1920s or 1930s. Hedgewar had started his political activism as a Congressman who organised young volunteers at the party's 1920 Nagpur session where Gandhi emerged as the 'undisputed leader'. Until then, there had been differences among Congress leaders over Gandhi's linking of the anti-British Non-Cooperation Movement with the Khilafat Movement in support of the Caliph of Istanbul. As Walter Andersen, a historian of the RSS, has noted, the original uniform